Collection

Toch HaNachal

(Within the Stream)

Wonderful words which were spoken

on *Shabbat Parshas Yisro* 5771

By the *Rav* and *Tzaddik*,

Mohorosh *Shlit"a*

Collected and Printed

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Friday Night, Parshas Yisro 5771

At the first meal, Mohorosh *Shlit"a* spoke inspiring words regarding the verse (*Shemos* 18:1) "And Yisro…heard".

Mohorosh began saying: It is written (*Shemos* 18:1) "And Yisro the priest of Midian, Moshe's father-in-law, heard of all that G-d had done for Moshe, and for Israel his people, and that Hashem had brought Israel out of Egypt." Rashi says, "What report did he hear that made him come? He heard about the splitting of the Red Sea and the war with Amalek." We need to understand, why in particular is it these two reports that brought him closer more than anything else?

Perhaps we can understand this with the words of our holy sages that the splitting of the Red Sea was in the merit of Yosef *HaTzaddik*, as stated in Midrash (*Tehillim* 114:3), "'The sea saw it and fled.' What did it see? It saw Yosef's coffin." This is because Yosef *HaTzaddik* showed us how to encourage ourselves even in the most difficult and bitter tests; by remaining firm in his faith, with constant happiness. Because Yosef *HaTzaddik* experienced much suffering and distress in his younger days: his brothers hated him, they envied him to the point where they threatened to kill him, and chased dogs after him; afterwards, they threw him in a ditch and sold him as an Egyptian slave. Egypt was no walk in the park either, he was wrongfully accused of the incident with Potifar's wife and was placed in prison. Throughout all this, he never abandoned his faith; rather, he directed his prayers towards the Heavens and always prayed to Hashem to find grace in everyone's eyes and to be saved from all evil, as our holy sages stated (*Tanchuma Vayeishev*) on the verse (*Bereishis* 39:3) "'And his master saw that Hashem was with him' – that Hashem's Name never departed from his lips. When his master entered the room Yosef would whisper: 'Master of the Universe, You are my Security, You are my Supporter, grant me grace, kindness and mercy in Your eyes and in the eyes of all those who look upon me, and in the eyes of Potifar my master.' When Potifar saw him doing this he said to him, 'What are you whispering, what spells are you casting upon me?' Yosef responded, 'No, I am praying to Hashem in order for Him to grant me grace in your eyes'."

Likewise we find that Yosef was very outstanding in the attribute of joy, even when he was in prison, as our holy sages stated (*Bereishis Rabba* 86:4) "He was successful in everything he did; he was a jumping man" – meaning, happy and joyful. Therefore, when he saw that the other prisoners were irritable, he was not able to bear their sadness, and asked them (*Bereishis* 40:7), "Why do you look sad

today?" Someone who's truly happy is not able to bear seeing others in a state of sadness. We see from this that Yosef *HaTzaddik* possessed a great level of inner-strength and would not allow himself to become broken by any circumstance in the world. Therefore, when the sea saw his coffin, it fled and ran away, because his merit and strength remained among the Children of Israel, who were likewise able to stand firm even in their extremely difficult situation, without giving up on themselves at all. Therefore, the sea was forced to split before them and allow them to pass, just as one who admits and recognizes their strength and might; that they have the power to pass and withstand every situation and not allow anything to break them.

This is what caused Yisro to come very close, because he saw a People who were at the epitome of holiness, and how they endured everything in order to strengthen their faith in Hashem. Yisro saw how they strengthened themselves with the power of Yosef *HaTzaddik* to the point where the sea was compelled to split before them. When he heard this report he came, for he understood that it is fitting to be bound to such a holy People who strengthen themselves in every situation imaginable. From this he was able to encourage himself that although he had previously pursued all types of idolatry and false beliefs in the world, he was no longer afraid of them at all just as Yosef wasn't afraid by all that he experienced; rather, he strengthened himself in every situation in life.

So too the war against Amalek caused him to come and convert; because the war against Amalek demonstrated the Jewish People's great strength to stand firm against the other nations which attacked them and wanted to cool them off from their holiness. Because after the splitting of the Red Sea, the entire world trembled before the Jewish People, as it is written (*Shemos* 15:14) "The people heard and were afraid; sorrow took hold of the inhabitants of Philistia." Nevertheless, Amalek dared to come and wage war against them; causing them to become cold and lax in their Divine service, as it is written (*Devarim* 25:18) "Who met you (cooled you off) on the way." Rashi states, "This can be compared to a boiling hot bath into which no one would dare enter. One villain came and jumped into it. Although he was scalded, he cooled it off for others." Nevertheless, the Jewish People fought against him and weakened his strength, as it is written (*Shemos* 17:13), "And Yehoshua weakened Amalek and his people with the edge of the sword." They continue waging this war against Amalek in each and every generation until his memory will be obliterated altogether, as it is written (verse 16), "Hashem will wage war against Amalek from generation to generation." Because in each generation the seed of Amalek fights against the Jewish People in order to cool them off from their Divine service, G-d forbid. They are represented by the brazenness of the

nations of the world who pursue the Jewish People in order to cool them off from their Divine service of Hashem. These nations issue decrees against them and seek to harm them, G-d forbid. However, the Jewish People are not afraid of them at all; rather, they continue to wage war against them and sacrifice themselves to once again build synagogues, Houses of Study, Torah institutions, schools for children, *mikvahs* and centers for the needy; all to show that they're not afraid of Amalek's impurity at all. All this caused Yisro to come very close, for he saw a holy nation who *are* able to stand and arouse themselves, even after all that happened to them. Yisro understood that this can only come from a holy source on High, which stands firm for all eternity. This brought him to the final conclusion, that it is very proper to bind oneself to such a nation.

This is what Yisro said (*Shemos* 18:11), "Now I know that Hashem is greater than all the gods," because he learned from Yosef *HaTzaddik*'s example, as well as the Jewish People's strengthening themselves after the war against Amalek, that it *is* possible to rectify everything and stand firm against the difficulties one experiences during his life. This compelled him very much to become a Jew, because prior to him coming he served all types of idolatry known in the world (as Rashi explains on this verse); and now that he wanted to come close to Israel's faith, his mind became weakened asking: "How will I ever be able to rectify each limb which I used for idolatry and strengthen myself from now on in every situation in life?" However, when he reflected upon the incident of the splitting of the Red Sea which came about by the strength of Yosef *HaTzaddik*, as well as how Israel reacted after the war against Amalek, he understood well from all this that it *is* possible to rectify everything and stand firm in each situation in life. Therefore, the holy *Zohar* states (*Yisro* 69) that when Yisro said, "Now I know that Hashem is greater than all the gods," Hashem's Name was made great in all the upper and lower worlds. Because when Yisro understood well that it *is* possible to return in perfect *teshuvah* from all of the idolatries in the world, and that "there's no despair in the world at all;" through this Hashem's Name was made great in all worlds. This showed him a real-life example that nothing stands in the way of *teshuvah* and it *is* possible to fix everything, because "there's no despair in the world at all!" And may Hashem grant us the merit of strengthening our pure faith in every situation, becoming elevated and bound to Him in truth and simplicity, until we merit being included in Him altogether, from now and forever. *Amen v'amen*.

